



United States
Attorney's Office
Western District of Virginia



Doctor at L5 Pain Clinic Sentenced to 40 Months in Prison, Ordered to Pay \$35,000 Fine and \$200,000 in Forfeiture

Wednesday, June 11, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Western District of
Virginia

Duane Dixon Worked at Clinics in Lynchburg, Madison Heights, and Christiansburg

ROANOKE, Va. – A former doctor, who concealed health care fraud and prescribed highly-addictive opioid painkillers to at-risk patients at pain clinics in Central and Southwest Virginia, was sentenced yesterday to 40 months in federal prison and ordered to pay \$200,000 in forfeiture and a \$35,000 fine.

Duane Dixon, 66, of Bedford, Massachusetts, pled guilty in 2023 to conspiring to distribute fentanyl and other opioids without a legitimate medical purpose and failing to report a pattern of health care fraud at clinics operated by L5 Medical Holdings—an LLC which was doing business as Pain Care Center, a line of pain clinics that formerly operated in Woodlawn, Lynchburg, Madison Heights, Blacksburg, and Christiansburg.

Dixon agreed as part of his plea agreement to surrender his medical licenses and to never practice medicine again.

"Duane Dixon prioritized profit over patient care," Acting United States Attorney Zachary T. Lee said today. "Our nation is fighting an opioid epidemic on a scale we have never seen and doctors like this, who take advantage of the addictions of others for their own greed, must be held accountable."

"We will not tolerate anyone who abuses their position and betrays the trust of American citizens by exploiting their vulnerabilities. Dr. Dixon clearly showed a lack of respect for human life, as his reckless and fraudulent practices prioritize profits over the delicate lives of others. Our team is dedicated to the safety and well-being of all individuals across the nation. This commitment includes ensuring that licensed professionals adhere to the law and report any hazardous conduct," DEA Washington Division Special Agent in Charge Ibrar A. Mian said.

"This doctor betrayed his oath, exploited vulnerable Virginians, and pumped dangerous opioids into our neighborhoods, fueling addiction and tearing families apart. His selfish, reckless scheme contributed to the opioid epidemic and left entire communities to deal with the devastating consequences. Virginia's Medicaid Fraud Control Unit will continue to aggressively pursue any healthcare provider who abandons their oath, preys on vulnerable patients, and fuels addiction for profit," said Virginia Attorney General Jason Miyares.

"The defendant's illegal prescribing practices and violation of public trust endangered patients and took advantage of the addiction of others, all for personal gain," said Maureen Dixon, Special Agent in Charge for the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG) Philadelphia Regional Office. "HHS-OIG will continue to work with our law enforcement partners to ensure individuals involved in schemes that threaten patient safety and target our most vulnerable populations are held accountable."

According to testimony and court documents, Dixon pre-signed dozens of blank prescriptions over several years at L5. With Dixon's knowledge, staff filled out the prescriptions for Schedule II opioids, including fentanyl and oxycodone, and distributed them to patients who had not seen a qualified medical provider. Dixon admitted to agents that, shortly after starting work at L5, a local pharmacist said he was a "pill pusher" and L5 was a "pill mill," and some pharmacies refused to fill his prescriptions.

As part of his guilty pleas, Dixon agreed he facilitated illegal distribution of Suboxone by other medical providers who lacked the authority to prescribe the drug. Dixon did so by sharing his unique identification number, which is necessary to prescribe controlled substances, with those unqualified providers for them to use when relaying prescriptions to pharmacists.

Additionally, to obtain insurance payments, Dixon acknowledged in interviews and court filings he approved and signed patient files for patients he had not actually treated.

The other doctor whose records Dixon falsified—former Dr. Wendell Lewis Randall—was sentenced in March 2024 to 18 months in prison for his role and was known to Dixon and others within L5 to issue medically illegitimate prescriptions. In a recorded interview played at sentencing, Dixon stated Randall's patient file notes were "lousy," did not "justify[] why" Randall "was giving the pain medications," and would have been insufficient even for a medical student.

In addition to Dixon and Randall, five others have pled guilty in connection with drug or fraud crimes at L5 between 2015 and 2020. Charles Wilson Adams, Jr.—falsely held out by L5 as a trained medical professional—was sentenced to two years' imprisonment in 2022. Nurse practitioner Debra Shaffer received jailtime and a fine in 2023.

L5 owner John Gregory Barnes, former COO Jennifer Adams, and L5 itself have also pled guilty and are awaiting sentencing later this year.

The Drug Enforcement Administration, the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services – Office of the Inspector General, the Virginia State Police, and the Virginia Attorney General's Office – Medicaid Fraud Control Unit investigated the case.

Assistant United States Attorneys S. Cagle Juhan, Jason Scheff and Special Assistant United States Attorney and Assistant Attorney General Janine Myatt prosecuted the case for the United States.

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